EMPATHY MAP

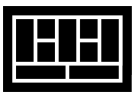


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SUPER GUIDE:
EMPATHY MAP

BY DANIEL PEREIRA



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INTRODUCTION

Any successful entrepreneur or CEO will tell you that the first step in creating a viable business plan is to understand what niche in the market you plan on filling. To understand this, you have to take a deep look into the mind of the average consumer and identify certain needs they may possess that the current market fails to adequately satisfy.

Following this, it's important to take this inward reflection even deeper by asking yourself, "Will they accept my solution to this need and at what cost?". Another pertinent question is, "What challenges would the average consumer encounter when utilizing my products or services?". These are just a few basic questions that you as an entrepreneur must answer before crafting a viable market solution.

At this point, it has become clear that a significant amount of retrospection into the mind of a consumer is required. That is to say, businesses must fully submerge themselves into the customer's experience and understand every facet of their interaction, both with the current problem you seek to solve and your proposed solutions as well.

This is an absolutely necessary step that many new and old businesses have been punished for not adequately utilizing. To correctly carry out this process it is necessary that businesses adopt a vital, but often overlooked skill — empathy.

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WHAT IS EMPATHY?

Empathy can be used in different contexts, however, for the sake of this guide, we will build upon the definition provided by the media organization Psychology Today, which states

"EMPATHY IS THE EXPERIENCE OF UNDERSTANDING ANOTHER PERSON'S CONDITION FROM THEIR PERSPECTIVE. YOU PLACE YOURSELF IN THEIR SHOES AND FEEL WHAT THEY ARE FEELING. EMPATHY IS KNOWN TO INCREASE PROSOCIAL (HELPING) BEHAVIORS. WHILE...CULTURE MIGHT BE SOCIALIZING PEOPLE INTO BECOMING MORE INDIVIDUALISTIC RATHER THAN EMPATHIC, RESEARCH HAS UNCOVERED THE EXISTENCE OF "MIRROR NEURONS," WHICH REACT TO EMOTIONS EXPRESSED BY OTHERS AND THEN REPRODUCE THEM."

Put simply, empathy is the ability to successfully understand another individual's perspective by viewing things through their point of view. Empathy is considered a vital "soft skill" within the business world, and one which has been receiving greater focus in recent years as businesses and brands attempt to overcome increasing competition by building stronger customer loyalty structures.

"Soft skills" — also known as core skills or common skills — are essentially personal attributes that all professionals

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require to support their situational awareness and help achieve tasks more effectively. The term is also closely related to emotional intelligence or the more commonly used people skills.

It's also important to note that the use of empathy can be extended to more than just your client base. It's also important to put yourself in the position of your employees and understand the constraints they face and how best you can boost productivity, innovation, and loyalty within the workplace. Another key aspect is looking at the world from the perspective of your key competitors. What potential market weaknesses do you have that they may seek to exploit, and how can these deficiencies be mitigated effectively?

WHY IS EMPATHY SUDDENLY SO IMPORTANT IN THE BUSINESS WORLD?

It is without saying that the business landscape has seen significant disruption in the past few years. The rapid rise in eCommerce, digital solutions, social media marketing, big data analytics, data-based advertising, and so on, has pushed for a stronger entrepreneurial-styled market backed by greater competition and increased consumer-merchant interactions.

With the current landscape encouraging deeper consumer-merchant relationships, businesses must develop and sustain such associations. This is because many buyers rank brand imaging and customer relationship as very important factors when choosing a product.

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WHAT ARE SOME KEY ADVANTAGES OF ADOPTING THIS SOFT SKILL TO YOUR BUSINESS MODEL?

Obviously, the importance of empathy in the business world cannot be overemphasized. Let's take a look at some of the key advantages of employing empathy in various parts of your business.

Increased Sales

As we mentioned earlier, one of the best ways to drive sales in this ever-increasingly competitive market environment is to place yourself in the position of your potential customers. This allows you to view the market through their unique perspective and understand the desires, challenges, and expectations they have. This allows you to adequately position your product or service in such a manner as to capitalize on these and drive more sales.

Greater Customer Retention

Another challenge that many businesses are facing with such a decentralized marketplace is the issue of customer retention. As expected in a truly competitive market where the consumer is exposed to a wide range of information, the average consumer is always on the look for the best deal in terms of price, convenience, and results.

Employing an empathetic model allows you to preempt the thinking process of the average consumer and discover innovative ways to capitalize on these traits to build a long-lasting business relationship. For example, many airlines offer special perks to frequent users of the airline. Also, many businesses maintain a dedicated mailing list because they

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understand that customers appreciate having regular interactions with their favorite brands.

More Referrals
In the business world, a good reputation is probably one of the most important aspects of advertising. Customers are more likely to recommend brands that they have personally used and have found to be quite satisfactory. This is especially true if the brand has built a personal relationship with its clientele by understanding its basic needs and expectations.

Increased Productivity
Empathy is not only applied to the consumer-merchant dynamic, it is also quite useful when dealing with employees as well. The goal of any employer should not be to run their employees to the ground in an outdated model of boosting productivity through longer hours and ever-increasing output quotas.

By placing themselves in the shoes of their employees, a good employer will be able to adopt methods that allow them to get the maximum output from their employees while still maintaining general well-being and cohesion within the workplace.

Enhanced Innovative Potential
Increased empathy within the workplace also has the potential to build confidence, creativity, and collaboration among workers. This boosts innovation, as this fosters an environment that promotes the sharing of ideas within the workplace and a drive to improve productivity.

Expanded Business Collaborations and Alliances
Empathy also encourages businesses to consider the perspective of other companies around them as well. This can be used as an opportunity to look at your business

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through the eyes of a competitor and discover potential shortcomings they may wish to exploit.

It can also be used to discover potential collaborations between you and other business entities which may produce mutually beneficial results. Many successful businesses run alliances with allied companies to drive down production costs, boost productivity, increase their customer base and streamline their business model.

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WHY DO SOME BUSINESSES WHICH FAIL TO APPLY EMPATHY FAIL?

There are many reasons why businesses fail. They could be due to poor management, lack of resources, internal sabotage, a change in existing market dynamics, and so on. However, a lack of empathy is often a silent cause because it is usually attributed to other factors. Let's take a look at some common ways a lack of empathy may lead to product or business failure.

PLACING COMPANY GOALS BEFORE CONSUMER VALUES

The primary goal of any business is to maximize its profit while successfully marketing its product or service to interested customers. The primary goal of any consumer is to obtain the best value from a product or service, both in terms of usefulness and cost. Most times this eventually leads to a steady equilibrium which both parties find mutually beneficial.

However, in certain situations, a business may make the mistake of placing its goals before the demands of its consumers. This may occur in several ways. For example, in an attempt to create a niche for themselves as the "first manufacturers of safe cigarettes", the RJ Reynolds cigarette

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company launched a line of smokeless cigarettes in 1988.

This, however, did not go down well with the consumers who never demanded such a product, found the chemical taste of the product unpleasant, and sorely missed the smoke and burn associated with traditional cigarettes. The product was quietly discontinued after the company had sunk almost 1 billion dollars into the product.

PLACING YOUR SHAREHOLDERS BEFORE YOUR CUSTOMERS

As we said, the primary purpose of a business is to maximize profits for its shareholders. However, it's important to remember that in a manner, the customers are the greatest shareholders of any firm. The practice of placing shareholders before your customers can lead not only to the failure of a product launch, but catastrophic business failure as well.

FAILING TO CONNECT WITH THEIR AUDIENCE

One of the key advantages of employing an empathy map early on is that it allows you to correctly identify your customer segment early on before significant resources have been invested and plan the best way of building a sustainable relationship with them. This can save you from a catastrophic product launch down the line which may turn out to be damaging to your brand image.

For example, the "ink! Coffee" company received serious

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backlash after an awful marketing campaign in Denver that appeared to support gentrification. This did not sit well with local residents, who in turn organized massive protests and demonstrations against the brand, even leading to vandalism. The company was quick to pull the offending quote and tender an apology, but the damage had already been done.

FAILING TO IDENTIFY YOUR CUSTOMERS

A product should always be launched with a particular market segment in mind. This helps maximize sales and allows you to streamline your product features toward providing maximum functionality for that particular customer segment. Releasing a product with no definitive customer is a recipe for disaster and typically leads to low sales and poor market adoption.

A way of combating this is correctly identifying your customer segment and building a solid user story or user persona using the principles outlined in an empathy map. This gives you a firm understanding of who your product is for and what best you can do to ensure they adopt it.

FAILING TO FOSTER A SUPPORTIVE WORK ENVIRONMENT

Although empathy maps have traditionally been targeted toward customers, they can be used by managers as tools to better understand their employees as well. To build a successful workforce and maintain optimal productivity it is important to understand what motivates your workers and the challenges they face in the workforce.

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A good empathy map can help you do that and build a more productive working environment that operates smoothly. This is also important in terms of innovation. Innovation works best under conditions where workers are optimally motivated. This is greatly important because innovation is the life hood that drives any successful enterprise and without steady innovation, most businesses are doomed to failure.

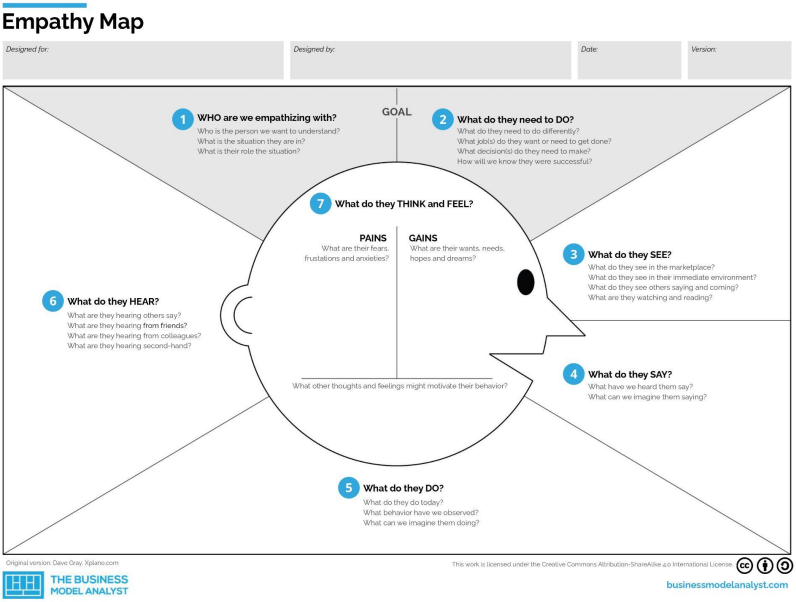
FAILING TO IDENTIFY WEAKNESSES

It's an unfortunate fact that many business owners are oblivious to the faults and weaknesses of their own businesses, a fact that many competitors seek to exploit. By placing yourself in the position of your customer or competitor, you can identify key areas of weakness or challenges that your business faces.

These areas of weakness also open up an opportunity for potential collaboration between your company and other allied businesses. This helps you streamline your services and focus on strengthening the areas you are most effective at, while the other allied businesses focus on the other areas involved in the delivery of the product or service.

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UNDERSTANDING THE EMPATHY MAP



Understanding the importance of empathy in the business world is one thing, but being able to effectively employ it as an integral part of your business strategy is another challenge altogether. Thankfully, various creative thinkers and innovators have searched for a solution to this issue and from their efforts, we were able to obtain a reliable tool — the empathy map.

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WHAT IS AN EMPATHY MAP?

An empathy map is a pictorial tool that can be used by various organizations and individuals as a framework for building, analyzing, and understanding the behavioral aspects of your customer base. The aim of using such a resource is to visually map out certain aspects of client behavior that may be of key interest to you such as their needs, expectations, challenges, perceptions, actions, and so on.

The purpose of this is to build a better understanding of your customer segment, their problems, and how you can position your company to solve them. Therefore, it is pertinent that at all times you remember that the consumer is the primary focus of the empathy map.

It is also important to remember to avoid falling into the trap of attempting to preempt your customers without adequate data. Building a solid empathy map requires a significant amount of customer-merchant interaction, both in terms of listening and talking. This can be through market analysis, online questionnaires, product pre-sales, interviews, and so on. The key is to gather as much information from your potential customer base as possible and interpret this in a useful manner.

WHO DESIGNED THE EMPATHY MAP?

The empathy map was originally designed by David Gray, an expert in the field of visual thinking and founder of Xplane, a firm that is dedicated to helping business leaders envision and successfully execute business strategies through an

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innovative combination of business consultancy expertise and the creative power of a design studio.

WHEN TO EMPLOY AN EMPATHY MAP

Empathy maps are flexible by design and can be successfully deployed in a wide range of practical applications. However, for the sake of simplicity, we will group these into four key situations in which you may find yourself needing help effectively immersing yourself in your subject's experiences.

- **When successfully building an extensive customer segment within a business model canvas**. A Business Model Canvas is a useful visual tool that can be used to build a basic layout of how a business operates. The standard chart is made up of nine core building blocks, which include a customer segment.

  A customer segment refers to the particular demographic that your product/service is targeted towards, e.g., lower-income/higher-income households, families/singles, and so on;

- **When attempting to elaborate on a user persona**. A user persona is a user-centered design and marketing tool that focuses on creating a fictional characterization of your ideal customer.

  This can be combined with the principle of market segmentation — which is similar to the customer segment tool —, that breaks the market into segments. By combining the two principles, you can build a unique user persona for each of your potential

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customer segments within the market;

- **During customer interviews**. Gathering information from potential or current customers can be quite tricky at times. This is especially true of businesses that are still unfamiliar with the proper techniques used in employing empathy and how to use them.

  An empathy map can be used as a framework to build your questions and point you in the right direction concerning the type of information you need to gather. This makes data collection much more efficient;

- **It can be used to craft a "user story"**. A user story can be defined as a concise description of the functionality offered by a product or service to a user. It is especially popular in the world of software and digital design. It can also be defined as a short representation of a user's goal and how this outcome can be achieved.

  Obviously, from the description above it is quite difficult to craft a user story without first obtaining a deep understanding of the needs, expectations, and challenges faced by the users themselves;

- **When trying to develop up- and cross-selling opportunities**. Upselling refers to the process of encouraging customers to purchase higher-end products. For example, offering a premium streaming subscription service which offers several key advantages such as an ad-free viewing experience.

  Cross-selling, on the other hand, involves encouraging customers to purchase similar or complementary products within the same category, for example, offering car insurance to individuals who purchased a

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new automobile;

- **It can be used to plan a marketing campaign**. For a marketing campaign to be truly effective, it requires a good understanding of the target demographic. This may include information on their preferred customer channels, current political and cultural views, trends, hobbies, and so on.

  This information can be used to increase brand appeal and reach out to a wider range of potential customers at the same time. Obviously, one of the best ways to accurately obtain, organize and visualize this information is through the use of an empathy map;

- **Build a stronger customer relationship management department**. Empathy maps are constantly evolving because even within specific customer and market segments, the preferences and characteristics of certain target demographics change constantly.

  Therefore, it is very important that customer relationship management departments are kept abreast with these changes and alter the brand outlook for the company accordingly to cater to their customers. This promotes long-term customer retention and builds your brand's image in the market.

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EMPATHY MAP QUADRANTS

Now that we have looked at what an empathy map is, why it should be used, and certain situations where empathy maps can be employed, it's important that we cover the next section — how to draw an empathy map.

PARTS OF AN EMPATHY MAP

As we mentioned earlier, an empathy map is a pictorial tool that can be used as a framework for building, analyzing, and understanding certain aspects of client behavior. Like most good visual tools, it is broken down into simpler subsections based on certain key principles.

Each of these subsections serves a key purpose and helps guide you on how the empathy map should be properly used and which areas are most important. This is important because at the end of the day, the primary goal of an empathy map is to aid in decision-making by creating a visual representation of user needs that can be easily understood and communicated.

Traditional empathy maps were divided into four quadrants based on key information that should be obtained concerning any customer, user persona, or user story. These are the Says, Think, Does, and Feels Quadrants. However, more recent empathy maps have been slightly modified. Both types of empathy maps will be covered extensively in this section.

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THE TRADITIONAL EMPATHY MAP

The traditional empathy map was a four-quadrant map that was designed to visualize certain key aspects of customer behavior. Let's take a closer look at each of these subsections and understand the necessary information we are required to obtain from them.

SAYS QUADRANT

As the name implies, this section of the empathy map is designed to deal with the **verbal information** given to you by the customer. It should contain direct quotes obtained from both past and present customers or users as they interact with your product, customer services, or any other customer channel.

These quotes can also be obtained from interviews, usability studies, surveys, online forums such as chat boards and social media, and so on. The aim is to obtain unfiltered comments from your customer base and on that note, it is ideal that these comments are quoted verbatim.

Some examples of possible comments which may be found under this section include:

- "The store has a wide variety of items. However, I found this to be quite overwhelming and this actually made it harder for me to make a choice";
- "The product design is amazing, but the cost and shipping delays were a major downside to the purchase";
- "I absolutely loved the product. It worked delightfully

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well and is much cheaper than other market competitors";

- "The newer version of the software is much quicker than the old one. However, I'm still getting used to some of the design changes they made".

THINKS QUADRANT

As the name implies, this part of the empathy map is more concerned with the thought process of the customer while interacting with your business or product. This can be regarded as a form of "inner monologue" or ideas that they failed to verbalize. This is important because users typically think a lot deeper than they bother to verbalize. It's also important to note that information for this section can be obtained through channels similar to that of the Says Quadrant, such as surveys, interviews, and so on.

For example, upon the launch of a new product or service, several users may verbalize difficulties they had with the product or their preference for the new design. While this may help you build an idea of whether your customers are in support of the new launch or not, they may not be insightful enough to enunciate the aspects of the new product or service which they prefer and those that caused significant displeasure.

Therefore, it is important that you extract this information through the use of guided statements, such as asking what they were thinking when using particular features. To elucidate this point, let's take a look at some practical examples:

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Example #1

What they said: “The product was great, but took too long to use”.

What they thought: “The login process is much longer than the previous design”.

This shows that even though their overall complaint was the length of time it took to utilize the product or service, their major area of difficulty was during the login process. Without further prompting, this may have never been discovered.

Example #2

What they said: “The product was great, however, I think an instruction manual would be a good idea for those who are unfamiliar with the brand”.

What they thought: “This design is much more complicated than similar brands, and I had significant difficulty setting it up”.

This highlights another key importance of the Thinks Quadrant, customers may feel the need to hide certain information due to self-consciousness, politeness, or guilt. Therefore, it’s a good idea to break down these barriers and understand the true meaning behind the words they tell you.

DOES QUADRANT

The Does Quadrant is another section that offers quite a bit of information. This is because it deals with the actions of the user during or after the use of a product or service. This may lend key information that even the user of the product is not aware of. This is because every action is guided by a reason

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or cause, one that users may frequently be unaware of.

This is best done through direct observation or recording, as user accounts may be inaccurate. Let's take a look at some examples of things that may be included under this section:

- How many times did the user refresh a page while waiting for it to load?
- How long did they wait before opening a new tab or abandoning the product?
- Was their decision-making influenced by the presence or absence of other individuals around them?
- Do most users hunt for the best bargain or simply purchase the first affordable product they come across?
- Do users become paralyzed with indecision when faced with many options, or simply choose the first option they see?

FEELS QUADRANT

The Feels Quadrant is also quite important because it can have a profound effect on the popularity or success of a product. It is related to the emotional state of the user while using the product. This section is usually the last part to be designed and helps tie together all the information obtained from previous sections. Let's look at a few examples:

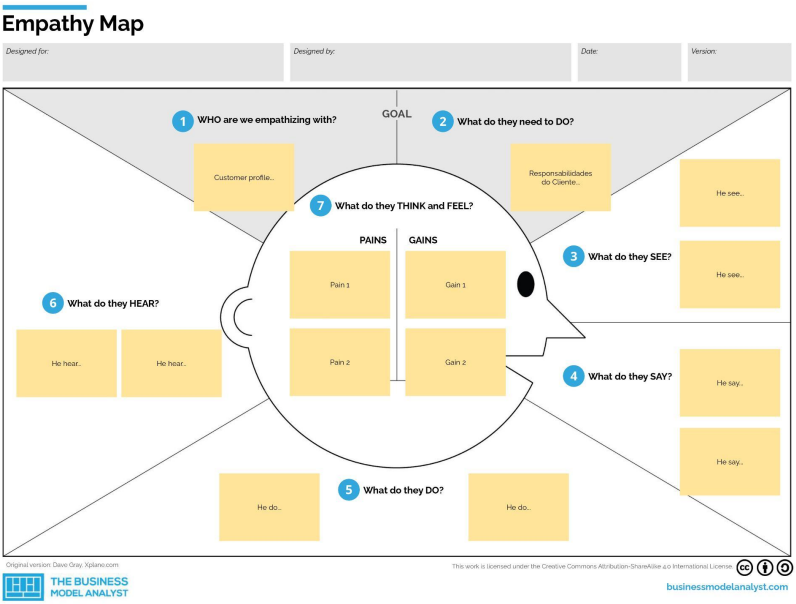
- Each loading screen takes too long - **frustrated**;
- The product came with so many delicate parts and few instructions - **anxious**;
- The new product offered a much wider variety of

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options compared to the last version - **happy**.

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EMPATHY MAP CANVAS



The Empathy Map Canvas is similar to the traditional four quadrants empathy map. However, this tool takes a deeper look at the inner workings of the ideal customer and further expands on the range of inputs they receive when interacting with a product or service.

There are several sections in the Empathy Map Canvas, which I've been further divided into subsections. Let's glance briefly over them before delving more dwelling into each section. They include:

- **The Goal**, this is further divided into **Who** the product is aimed at, and what do they intend to **Do** with the

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product?

- What did they **See**?
- What did they **Say**?
- What did they **Do**?
- What did they **Hear**?
- What did they **Think** and **Feel**?

The keg is to start from the Goal section and work your way through all these questions sequentially in a clockwise manner until all the subsections of the Empathy Map Canvas have been duly filled.

PARTS OF THE EMPATHY MAP CANVAS

#1 WHO Are We Empathizing With?
Obviously, when dealing with product development, this should always be the first question every responsible design team should ask. Who is this product for? Why is it aimed at them? What is their current situation, and how do they fit into all of this?

Answering these preliminary questions is very important for correctly building the rest of the Empathy Map Canvas, and any mistakes made here could have devastating effects down the line.

For example, a company might be planning on releasing a new line of advanced, quick-cleaning vacuum cleaners, and they need to build an empathy map to create an ideal user persona. At this step, they may decide that their primary

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target audience is middle-to-upper class housewives with large homes and little time for domestic chores.

This simple example has defined who the subject of the empathy map is, the problem they face, how they can solve this issue, and how your product can be of assistance in this situation. It's important to note that if you are creating multiple user personas, each of them will require a separate empathy map of their own.

#2 What Do They Intend to DO?
The first section of the Empathy Map Canvas clearly defined who the subject of the tool was and what challenge (s) they were faced with. The second section under the "Goal" heading is focused on the necessary steps that this individual needs to take to overcome this challenge, how this challenge is to be overcome, and how they will know that the task has been completed successfully.

Using the example of an overburdened housewife from the first section, we can easily identify the challenge as a large number of house chores but with little time for domestic work may be due to a part-time job, childcare, hobbies, and so on. We have also identified that this individual is most likely to come from a middle-to-higher income household and can therefore afford to purchase pricey home cleaning equipment like a high-end vacuum cleaner.

A basic rundown of the steps required to achieve this will include:

- Deciding to purchase a high-end vacuum cleaner;
- Researching for the best vacuum cleaners available;
- Purchasing the vacuum cleaner;

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- Having it delivered and setting it up;
- Successfully using the product.

Even though these steps may look simple, there are obvious business objectives hidden within them. For example, how can the company position itself to affect the customer's decision-making through advertising, referrals, brand image, competitive advantage, sales and promotions, and so on.

Also, how can the company affect the purchase and delivery aspect through modern financial solutions, a streamlined delivery chain, and even superb customer installation or customer support services.

Lastly, what can the company do to ensure maximum user satisfaction while the product is being utilized? This includes various innovative and commonly used design features. The sum of all this is to ensure that the user's ultimate goal was achieved — in this case, to shorten the burden of house chores, both in terms of time and effort.

#3 What Did They SEE?
This section is concerned primarily with visual perception. One of the first questions is what do potential consumers see in the marketplace when looking for a product? What features are currently popular? What is the latest design trend? Which issues are most pressing among consumers in that particular market segment?

The next questions to ask are what do they see in their immediate environment? What are they watching, reading, or seeing others say and do? This involves before purchasing the product, while using it, and when they are done.

This can be important for the purpose of advertising, receiving feedback, and observing a customer's reaction to

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the physical appeal of a product. Are your customers being adequately exposed to your marketing campaigns through your chosen channels?

Do they appreciate the product design, or is there some outward feature that needs to be changed? Do they see others within their market segment using your products as well? These are just some of the information that is vital under this section.

#4 What Do They SAY?
This could be in terms of verbal speech and written conversation obtained through surveys, online chat rooms, social media, and so on. One of the easiest ways to enter the mind of your customers is to closely monitor their conversations. What is the current trend? Do they have any complaints concerning a feature that accompanied your product or that of a product from a competitor? What features are they looking for?

It is also important that you are able to preempt their conversations to some extent and imagine what they "could say". However, remember to thoroughly test any idea with a study group before acting on it.

It's also a good idea to note **where** these conversations occur. Is it on online chat forums? Which social media platforms have you noticed are most popular among that particular market segment? Do they have a preference for physical interactions? All these will be very useful when trying to direct your market campaign successfully.

Lastly, you can obtain direct quotations from your customer through the use of questionnaires, surveys, interviews, comments, product reviews, and so on. This information is invaluable, and as much as possible should be stated in the customer's words verbatim.

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#5 What Did they DO?
This refers to their action before, while, and after utilizing your product or service. In terms of before utilizing your product, you can pose key questions such as; are they the type to purchase products online, or would rather go down to a physical store to purchase an item? Do they prefer home delivery? Do they spend a significant amount of time online? When are they most likely to use this product and in what way?

While your customer is using the product, it is important to take note of any difficulties they may have encountered, how they reacted to these difficulties, and how easy it was for them to overcome these challenges. Did they persevere or immediately switch to another product? Were there any features that were used incorrectly, or in the process did you incidentally discover a novel use for the product besides the primary function?

The last item to note is their observed behavior after using the item. Was it stored/shut down correctly? Did they have any difficulty with its disposal? Did they give positive or negative reviews? Did it achieve the aim it was intended to achieve? Did they ask for a refund?

#6 What Do They HEAR?
This section is quite similar to the information obtained from section #4 but deals more closely with auditory conversations. Auditory information can be just as impactful as visual stimuli, and should therefore not be easily dismissed.

Take a look at the type of information they receive from podcasts, media platforms, friends, family, and acquaintances. This can be quite useful in gaining a deeper understanding of your customer and their intentions.

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Obviously, this is also a potential marketing opportunity and a chance to control the narrative concerning your brand or product. Monitor these conversations closely and ally yourself with topics that are trendy among that particular market segment.

It's important to note how much of this information is obtained from first-hand witnesses and how much is just hearsay. This can give you a chance to identify important misconceptions which may be prevalent in the market and plan your business strategy accordingly.

#7 What Do They THINK and FEEL?

To some individuals, this is the most difficult part of crafting the Empathy Map Canvas because it does not deal directly with what a customer says, does, or hears, but rather with what they think and feel. This means that you have to truly get into the mind of your customer, and this may be quite a difficult task for those who are not armed with the right tools.

The first aspect of this section deals with what your customer **thinks** about before, while, or after using this product. As we mentioned earlier, it is very important to carefully differentiate this from what they say or do, in order to avoid falling into the trap of assuming that a customer's words or actions are completely representative of their thinking process. This is because words may at times fail to convert the true intent of a customer.

For example, a customer who describes a product as being difficult or unwieldy may have issues with only certain operations but finds that the product works quite well when used for other tasks. Without further probing into the actual thought process of the customer while using the product, this may not have been discovered.

Another important aspect to note while investigating this

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section is to take note of consumer motivations. Primary motivations usually have secondary or hidden factors behind them. For instance, a company that markets a line of orthopedic beds will probably find out that the primary motivation for buying their product is to get a “good night's sleep”. However, deeper investigation into their customers may show that a majority of their customers suffer from lower back pain, which can be a strong marketing point.

The second aspect deals with what your clients **feel** while using your product. This is distinctly different from what they think. Thinking typically has to do with a conscious effort, while feelings are mostly subconscious and the individual may not even be aware of them at the time. These feelings can be broken down into simple terms like frustration, satisfaction, anxiety, boredom, happiness, and so on.

One of the reasons that this section is so important is because many times customers do not form conscious biases against products, but actually respond based on feelings they had while using the product. So even if a device produced a good outcome, it may be seen unfavorably if its use was termed as “difficult”. These biases are dangerous as they can be quite damaging to the reputation of the brand itself.

The last item to be noted under this section is the category of **gains** and **pains**. **Gains** refer to what a user thinks or feels they can achieve through the use of this particular product or service. This can be in terms of wants, needs, expectations, hopes, and so on.

On the other hand, **pains** refer to challenges, fears, anxieties, or difficulties a customer expects to encounter while using this product. These fears may be real or imagined, and may even stem from past experiences with similar products from that same brand or other brands.

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HOW DOES THE EMPATHY MAP RELATE TO THE CONCEPT OF PERSONA?

When building an empathy map, it is important to remember that the key objective is to build a user persona that is reliable and representative through a feasibly repeatable process of data gathering. A user persona is one of the most fundamental building blocks of marketing because it allows brands to obtain a deeper understanding of customer behavior, habits and core characteristics.

It can be used as a precise tool to gather this information and craft it in an easily relatable form that highlights the key points and drowns out the unnecessary background noise. This fictional profile forms the basis for future product development and marketing campaigns. It is important to remember that user characteristics change, so an empathy map should also change over time.

Also, there are several concepts to keep in mind when using an empathy map to build a user persona. They include:

- **It should be representative**. A good empathy map should help you craft a user persona that accurately represents your target demographic as closely as possible. This involves knowing the right questions to ask so that you can easily sieve out useful data from other superfluous information. It also means ensuring

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that you obtain large amounts of data to help increase the reliability of your data set and extract real information from background noise;

- **It should be reliable**. One of the reasons that empathy maps are so popular is that they have stood the test of time as reliable visualization tools for building a great user persona. They have been applied across different industries and have been found to be easily adaptable to all these varied fields;

- **It should be flexible**. This flexibility can be defined in different ways. First of all, an empathy map should be flexible enough to be easily changed as the characteristics of your target demographic change, this is important because the market is not static and new opportunities present themselves constantly through the shifting trends within a marketplace.

  On another note, they should also be flexible enough to be adapted to different fields and produce reliable results;

- **It should be reproducible**. Empathy maps produce reproducible data. This means that two different development teams carrying out a study on the same or similar target demographics should also obtain similar results, as long as they carefully follow the rules of crafting an empathy map, and they collect a large amount of data;

- **It should be scalable**. One reason empathy maps are popular is that they can be used for both large-scale and small-scale applications. This makes them a feasible option for a wide range of businesses.

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HOW TO CREATE AN EMPATHY MAP?

It's important to understand the process of designing an empathy map as well as the contents. While there is no fixed set of sequences that must be strictly followed when designing an empathy map, a loose framework, can be closely followed to make the process as efficient as possible. These steps include:

SELECT YOUR SUBJECT

The first step of empathy map building is to choose the ideal customer profile you will use to build your user persona or user story. This of course requires a strong understanding of the market and the various market segments within it.

This stage will likely involve some preliminary research which will help you obtain a holistic understanding of the marketplace, where your product/service fits within it and the various customer segments it could appeal to. It is important to remember that you will have to craft a separate empathy may for each user persona, which is designed to represent an ideal customer within a target demographic.

GATHER YOUR DATA

After identifying your target demographic, it's time to obtain the necessary data that will be used to craft your empathy map. Sources of information can come from a wide range of

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channels which may include surveys, online chat forums, social media, product reviews, interviews, product pre-launches, beta testing, and so on. Remember to be as extensive as possible and ensure that your search for information is in-depth.

It is also quite important to keep the different sections of the empathy map in mind while sourcing this data. This will help you ensure that all the necessary information is being obtained and that no part of the user persona is being overlooked. This satay can also be gathered at different stages such as before, during, or after product use. After all this information has been gathered, it's time to move on to the next step.

GATHER YOUR SUPPLIES

You've identified your target demographic. You've collected the necessary information. Now it's time to gather your materials. Crafting empathy can involve tools ranging from complex visualization software to simple items such as notebooks, sticky notes, and writing utensils.

No particular method is advocated over the other, it is simply advisable to do what works best for you and is within your budget. If done correctly, they produce the same results. Also, don't forget that at times your supplies may be actual individuals such as interviewees or individuals who may offer personal insights or expertise.

ASSEMBLE YOUR TEAM

This involves bringing together everyone that is directly involved in product design as well as crafting of the empathy map. This will also include any interviewees or market experts you may have identified as well. These experts should be

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individuals who have made regular contact with the target demographic and will be able to offer some key insights.

When all the members of the team have been identified, regular meetings should be set up at a suitable time, location and date. Usually, crafting a functional empathy map may take more than one single session, so plan for multiple meetings. Also, avoid making each session drawn out to prevent mental fatigue, burnout, and loss of creativity. The point is to be as productive as possible, so keep meetings short — between 30 minutes to an hour — and impactful.

DRAW YOUR MAP

Now it's time to finally draw your empathy map. This can be done using any of the variations explained above. Remember that if you are using the Empathy Map Canvas, it is important to start from the **goals** sections and work your way through the other subsections in a clockwise manner, finally ending with the inner workings of the customer's mind.

To add a depth of realism you can create a fictional profile for your ideal customer which includes a name, age, background, hobbies, and other relevant information which may further aid you in creating a realistic user persona.

SUMMARIZE THIS INFORMATION

At this point, the empathy map has been completed, and the results are now ready to be discussed. The key thing here is to bring out the salient points that were identified and craft them into well-thought-out business strategies. It also gives room for any flaws to be identified and promptly corrected. After this, the finished empathy map is now ready to be distributed to the relevant departments.

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HOW TO USE EMPATHY MAPS TO DRIVE YOUR SAAS GROWTH

Unsurprisingly, empathy maps have been found to be quite useful when used within the Software-as-a-Service (SaaS) industry. This is most likely because software designers require significant knowledge about their customers to be able to design a product that will offer the best user experience. This involves placing themselves in their customer's shoes from the moment the product is purchased to when it has been used successfully.

This has led to the rise of various specialties within the software service industry, such as User Experience (UX) design and User Interface (UI) design. Both terms refer to different concepts, but both have to do with designing a product from the viewpoint of the user.

Obviously, such services have a lot to do with frontend development, since this is the part of the software that the user sees and interacts with. Therefore, a significant amount of customer research and empathy is required to create a meaningful user interface that supports both functionality and aesthetics.

However, a significant amount of effort is put into streamlining the user experience in terms of backend development as well. Even though users do not routinely interact directly with

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this part of the software, they can subconsciously acknowledge the quality of a good backend design simply by appreciating how streamlined and functional the entire program is.

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EXAMPLE OF A COMPLETE CUSTOMER EMPATHY MAP

Let's build a simplified empathy map using a fictional user persona to illustrate how this tool can be utilized practically within the market environment.

User Information: Jane is a 29-year-old scheduling team manager who just finished a 30-minute trial of the beta version of a new scheduling software. She was observed while utilizing the program and afterward answered a few questions from a member of the software development team. Here, there are a few of her answers.

- **Says Quadrant:** "The overall experience was nice, however, it took considerably longer to use than the older software. The price tag on this model is also a bit high, too";
- **Thinks Quadrant:** "The processing pages load too slowly, and it would be nice if they offered a better explanation for some of the new features. I think I prefer the old software";
- **Does Quadrant:** Clicks on the loading pages several times to check to try and speed up the process. Seems quite competent with familiar features, but has some difficulty with the newer additions to the program;
- **Feels Quadrant:** Frustrated by the slow loading pages and new features. Happy that the product retained

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some of its original features. Impressed by some of the newer tools that were added to the software;

- **Gains:** Newer, more efficient scheduling software which would make her job significantly easier;
- **Pains:** Frustrated by the slow loading pages and increased software price. Also, the inconvenience of having to learn how to operate several of the new functions which were incorporated into the product.

Keep in mind that this is a very simplified example of how an empathy map would look, and it only dealt with a few issues. However, this will give you a good idea of how a well-done empathy map can bring out spoken and unspoken insights.

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WHAT BENEFITS DOES THE EMPATHY MAP BRING TO THE MARKETING STRATEGY?

Let's quickly go through some of the unique benefits that you stand to gain by using an empathy map as a way of incorporating empathy into your business strategy.

INFORMATION DISTRIBUTED IN A CLEAR VISUAL ANALYSIS

Visual analysis and the representation of information in a pictorial form have several key advantages. First of all, complex and vague concepts can be better conceptualized in concrete terms through the use of pictures and graphics. This also helps break them down into simpler ideas through the use of color-coding, subdivision, and flowcharts.

Another advantage of visual analysis is that it makes it easier to remember large amounts of data. The human brain is wired to process visual data much more quickly and efficiently than any other type of information, which is why graphical presentations are so important during the learning process.

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Visual information is also more inspiring. Most people will agree that large walls of block text rarely inspire the creativity or innovative drive required to foster progress. However, a visual tool like an Empathy Map Canvas and user persona can help you create the impression of truly existing within the mind of the customer.

A BETTER UNDERSTANDING OF THE BRAND'S AUDIENCE

At the end of the day, the main function of an empathy map is to create an immersive experience that gives you an in-depth understanding of your target demographic. The visual graph itself is just a pictorial tool and not the end goal, so it is important to always ensure that at the end of crafting an empathy map that a user persona of your ideal customer has been made.

A key advantage of an empathy map is that this information is mainly sourced through direct interactions between the brand and its customers. This helps build a deeper personal relationship between the company and its target demographic. It also ensures that the information being received is accurate.

QUICK IMPLEMENTATION AND LOW COSTS

Another advantage of empathy maps is that they can be implemented quite quickly. Once all the required data has been obtained. The next step is to hold a brainstorming session with key team members aimed at building the

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empathy map. Usually, a session should not last for longer than an hour to promote maximum productivity. If it does, several sessions should be fixed.

Empathy maps are also a low-cost alternative to other forms of user persona building. Even though some individuals may prefer to use expensive data visualization software, a good empathy map can be drawn up with a few cheap writing utensils.

IMPORTANT INSIGHTS FROM THE PROFILE ANALYSIS

Another great feature of empathy maps is their ability to succinctly bring out various important insights from the profile analysis of the customer, which may drive innovation or strategy changes that vastly increase profit and productivity. These insights may range from seemingly minor details such as the range of colors favored by a large variety of consumers, to industry-changing discoveries such as the emergence of new niches within the ever-changing market environment.

For example, creating several empathy maps of different core market segments for a product may demonstrate that a significant number of its customers are not particularly active in social media. Therefore, an extensive resource-consuming social media campaign would be counterintuitive. Diverting these resources toward other customer channels or departments is more likely to increase productivity.

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THEY OFFER VERSATILITY AND FLEXIBILITY

Empathy maps are flexible tools that can be adapted to a wide range of uses, aside from just gaining useful insights into consumers. They can also be utilized by companies to better understand their workers as well and boost productivity.

Empathy maps can also be adapted to a wide range of industries due to the fact that they come in various forms and can be tailored to focus on the particular areas which are most relevant to the industry in question.

THEY ARE REPEATABLE AND RELIABLE

Another major advantage of empathy maps is that they can be repeated by different groups of individuals in the same market segment and obtain similar results as long as a large amount of data is obtained. This makes them repeatable and reliable, something that development teams appreciate.

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EMPATHY MAPS IN B2B

A business-to-business (B2B) model refers to companies whose main customers are other businesses — as opposed to ordinary consumers. B2B businesses can also adopt the empathy map, however, due to the peculiar nature of their “ideal customers” certain modifications have to be made.

One interesting thing to note is that there is a lower degree of uniformity among empathy maps built for businesses within the same market segment than among consumers. This is because a single business typically has multiple stakeholders, each of which has its specific duties, goals, and challenges within the business environment. Therefore, the empathy map must be carefully tailored to take account of this peculiarity.

However, there are still several general key areas that are important to note. These include taking cognizance of the business size, industry-specific characteristics, consumer base, shareholder characteristics, leadership style, and so on.

WHY USE EMPATHY MAPS IN B2B

Empathy maps are just as useful for B2B companies as they are for other business models. Due to the varied nature of different departments within a single business, it is important to fully understand their characteristics, objectives, and challenges.

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STEPS TO USE EMPATHY MAPS IN B2B

Building an empathy map for a B2B business is similar to a standard empathy map. However, there are a few key differences that you have to take into account. Here are the steps involved in building an empathy map for a B2B business.

Identify the Relevant Stakeholders

Within a company, there are typically various departments, each of which is in charge of different tasks designed to keep the business running smoothly. However, it would be a mistake to simply assume that an entire department may be the subject of your empathy map.

Even within departments, there may be relevant stakeholders who are the core market segment you need to reach out to. For example, assuming you are a SaaS company that wishes to sell an innovative scheduling service to a company, it is important that you first identify who exactly you are marketing the product to.

Within a large firm, you may find an administrative department, under which there is typically a workforce management division. Within the workforce management division, there is a scheduling team who are in charge of drafting worker schedules, appointments, and so on. Even though they may not be the ones making the final decision on whether to purchase your services or not, they should be the key focus of your empathy map.

Identify Other Groups Which May Affect the Stakeholders' Decision-Making

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isolation. There are numerous horizontal and vertical relationships within a business, and these affect decision-making among these departments to varying degrees. You must identify these relationships, the manner in which they affect each other, and the strength of this involvement.

Select Your Goal

This is a simple technique to help you streamline the process of building your empathy map by focusing on a single issue at a time. For example, your goal may be to “sell a new product to company A” or “test the feasibility of marketing a new line of services to a particular market segment”.

Build Your Empathy Map

Now that you have taken note of these key points, it’s time to build the empathy map. This is quite similar to the process of building a normal empathy map, but remember that you are dealing with a business, not a customer.

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TIPS FOR EFFECTIVE EMPATHY MAPPING

Drawing an empathy map may seem difficult at times. Here are some tips that can help you build an effective empathy map.

AVOID LETTING YOUR BIASES AFFECT YOUR DECISIONS

It is normal to have both conscious and unconscious biases on a wide range of topics. However, an empathy map is meant to be as unbiased and objective as possible. There are several ways to combat biases. The first step is to try to be aware of your biases and double-check every bit of information you accept or dismiss. Another good idea is to have several individuals look at the information from different perspectives. Lastly, every piece of information should be backed up with factual data.

BUILD YOUR FOUNDATION ON FACTUAL DATA

Using solid data isn't just a way to avoid biases, it also helps add credence to your empathy map. An empathy map that is built with data from well-constructed questions and reputable

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sources is much more effective when implemented. Data can come from different sources and in different forms, so it's important that you have a good team that is skilled at different forms of data analysis.

ALWAYS BE ON THE LOOKOUT FOR NEW OPPORTUNITIES

The market is extremely dynamic. New trends appear constantly and disappear just as quickly. Within these shifts in customer preferences, goals and challenges await numerous market opportunities that can be capitalized upon.

INVEST IN A ROOT CAUSE ANALYSIS

Even though customers within a particular market segment can vary widely, there are usually similar characteristics that bind them together. Typically, many of these common characteristics can be traced back to a deep-rooted set of ideas and beliefs that are prevalent among that particular target demographic. For example, millennials from different backgrounds usually have a common love for social media and internet technology due to the fact that they grew up in a world of greater social interconnectivity than their predecessors.

TIPS FOR MAKING EMPATHY MAPS WITH REMOTE TEAMS

Sometimes it will be necessary to work remotely with a team while building an empathy map, so it's important that you are aware of a few simple tips which can make this process much

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easier.

Invest in Video Conferencing Technology
Distance is much less of a barrier now than it was several decades ago. Video conferencing technology now allows teams that are working remotely from each other to meet regularly and discuss topics in real time. This makes outlining your purpose, delegating duties, receiving progress reports, and setting deadlines much easier.

Use Project Management Tools
Project management tools help you keep your tasks well-organized and allow you to closely follow the progress of the entire project from a single terminal. This also makes delegating smaller tasks to various members of your team much easier as well.

Use a Shared Document
This allows you and your team to make shared edits and closely observe each other progress. Added information can be easily highlighted, comments made and corrections made with minimal difficulty.

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HOW EMPATHY MAPS SIMPLIFY DECISION-MAKING

Empathy maps are great for aiding decision-making, but sometimes they offer so much information that development teams find themselves paralyzed by the vast number of decisions before them. Nevertheless, there is a way to make this process easier.

One of the main things to keep in mind when using empathy maps is that you are advocating on the behalf of the user, not just trying to increase your profit or productivity. Keeping these ideas at the forefront of your mind when making any major user-related decisions can help you simplify the decision-making process into just a few key concepts.

- Does this decision improve user experience?
- Does this decision help solve any of the challenges faced by the user?
- Does this decision enhance the brand's image in the eyes of the user or increase their loyalty to the brand?
- Can this help the user achieve a particular objective?
- Will this action positively improve the user's decision-making?

Filtering every decision made through these questions can

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go a long way in simplifying the process of utilizing an empathy map.

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CONCLUSION

Empathy maps are amazing tools that offer a visual representation of a particular target demographic taking into consideration their characteristics, motivations, challenges, preferences, and influences. It is a great tool for a wide variety of businesses and has different applications. There are several different types of empathy maps, but all of them have the same primary function — to produce a reliable user persona representing the ideal customer.

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